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**PAUL
GARLAND**

**A CUCKOLD
CHRISTMAS
CAROL**

A SEXY SEASON SHORT

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Mean businessman Paul Scrogie is taken on an enlightening journey by four spirits, each showing him the errors of his ways. As he learns the ego-crushing truth about why his ex-wife left him and what his current girlfriend is doing when his back is turned, Paul is forced to change his attitude towards not only his lack of generosity and affection, but also his attitude to sex.

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Foreword

Welcome to my second 'Sexy Season Short', a collection of short stories designed to be not quite as serious and down-to-earth as my No Angels, Cuckold Collection or Cerulean Erotica Presents series - rather these naughty shorts should be treated as small but salacious flights of fancy - fun fantasies with a sprinkling of kink and a whole dollop of dirty but delightful indecency.

This first attempt at such a project was Tracy's Trick or Treat, a celebration of October 31st, not only my birthday (it really is!) but also the famous holiday of Hallowe'en.

My second comes to you in the form of 'A Cuckold Christmas Carol,' an erotic reworking of the Charles Dickens classic but with a hotwife twist.

I hope you enjoy it - like my Hallowe'en story, it was definitely a lot of fun (and again, different) to write. My next seasonal short will be released in February - with the theme being Valentine's Day, so keep an eye out for that one!

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Chapter 1

Marlene was dead, to begin with. Of that, there could be no doubt. I, myself, signed the death register for her, and anything I signed my name to was good and right. Yes, Marlene was as dead as a doornail.

Not that there's anything dead about a doornail. Myself, if I was to pick a piece of ironmongery that better suited the word dead, I would choose coffin-nail. But the wisdom of our ancestors gave birth to the simile, so I shall not be the one to try to change that, but you will allow me to reinforce the fact, once more, that Marlene was dead.

Of course, I knew she was dead; she and I were business partners for a long time. Even now, my warehouse and factory have the name 'Paul Scrogie and Marlene Jacobs' above our main company sign. I'd never take Marlene's name from there, even though she was completely and irrefutably dead.

The reason you have to understand this fact of Marlene being deceased is that without it, this story will have no real meaning. To think that Marlene might - somehow - still be alive invalidates everything.

As I stepped under the sign still bearing my old partner's name and into the warehouse I owned, out of the freezing temperatures of the late winter afternoon outside, I nearly bumped into a tall, slim man with a red scarf pulled so tight around his neck that it made him look almost like a turkey. I didn't recognise him until he said my name.

"Paul, there you are." He took me into an unwanted hug to which I didn't respond until he released me somewhat awkwardly. "You're freezing cold. Close the door. I've been waiting for you."

“I don’t feel the cold,” I shrugged. “I overheard one of my employees the other day-” I gave my pretty receptionist Bobbi a pointed look, “They said that no winter day is cold enough to chill me because my heart is made from ice.”

“Well, that’s a bit mean.” The stranger also gave Bobbi a reproachful look. “Anyway, look, I haven’t seen you for years. I wanted to come by, say Happy Christmas and invite you for dinner tomorrow.”

“You haven’t seen me for years?” I stared at the fellow, then finally realised who it was. The man standing in front of me was my brother Fred. I hadn’t recognised him right away because he’d had a beard when I’d last seen him - which must be at least five years ago. He’d also lost a lot of weight. My little brother had always been the chubbier one of us two, not difficult when I was stick-thin and always had been.

“It must be nearly five years,” Fred confirmed what I’d just been thinking. “You’ve never even met your youngest niece. You should come over. Helen would love to see you.”

No, she wouldn't. Helen despised me. She'd tried to befriend me years ago, when they first got together and then again when they had their first child - a boy, I couldn't remember his name - but again, I distanced myself. I think she saw me as rude. I wasn't rude. I'm not a rude man. I just don't really do the whole family thing. Back then, it was just me and Bella, my wife at the time, our son, Tim, and my business partner, Marlene. They were the only people I wanted - or needed - in my life.

“I don’t celebrate Christmas,” I informed Fred. “So thank you for the kind offer, but no thank you, all the same.”

“Oh, come on, Paul,” Fred said, smiling warmly as though he had some chance of changing my mind through charm alone. “We’re brothers. Since mum and dad passed, we’re the only family we’ve got.”

“What does that have to do with Christmas?” I asked, taking off my coat and looking through the mail on Bobbi’s desk.

“Christmas is all about family,” Fred grinned. “Since Bella and you split, we’ve barely heard from you. You’re not getting any younger and since Tim moved to France, I worry about you being all on your own.”

“I’m not on my own all the time,” I pointed out. “I have Claire, remember. You know about Claire. If I recall, she wrote back to your last letter when I didn’t have time.”

“Yes, Claire has replied to a few of my letters,” Fred nodded. “But I also know she spends a lot of time at her family’s house down south, including Christmas, because she told me so. No one should spend Christmas on their own, so why not come and spend it with us? We can catch up. Talk about the old times.”

“Fred,” I said, beginning to lose my patience with my annoying little brother. “As I said, thank you but no. You celebrate Christmas in your way, let me do it in mine.”

“But you don’t celebrate,” Fred shook his head. “It’s a shame. Never mind. I hoped you might have changed; softened, now you’re getting older, but apparently not. Still, I won’t let you dampen my spirits. Merry Christmas, brother. Merry Christmas, miss.” He waved to Bobbi who waved back until she saw me glaring at her, then he left, stomping away through the snow outside.

“I didn’t know you had a brother,” she commented after he’d gone.

“How would you?” I asked. “Get on with your work.”

Bobbi was gorgeous; long dark hair, chocolate coloured skin; huge brown eyes. I shouldn’t look at her the way I did, she was thirty years younger than me, but I couldn’t help it. Those young curves were a sight for my old sore eyes every day when I came to the warehouse. Then again, my girlfriend, Claire, was twenty years younger than me but the opposite to Bobbi; she was all curves, big breasts, blue eyes and blonde hair. So, Bobbi was only another ten years younger than my current partner. That wasn’t too bad, even if Bobbi was only just out of her teens, I would fuck her if the opportunity ever came up. I’d be lying to myself if I said otherwise.

“Mr Scrogie,” someone said, opening the door and sticking their head through.

“Yes?” I sighed at yet another unwelcome visitor.

“Merry Christmas,” he said, stepping through after kicking the snow from his shiny shoes. “My name is Nick. I’m from the local care home, collecting for charity. I wondered if you might be able to help us out with a small Christmas gift this year.”

“I’m sorry,” I said, turning my back on him dismissively. “I have my own charities that I support.”

“Ah, yes, but the thing is, you see.” I heard the man shuffling his feet, obviously not wanting to leave without pleading his case. “We’re really struggling this year. Our government funding has dropped and we find ourselves today, on Christmas Eve, a thousand pounds short of what we normally spend at this time of year to give the elderly and vulnerable residents a nice Christmas. So, I wondered, with you being a well-known wealthy local gentleman...”

“I am wealthy, yes,” I nodded, turning to face him. “Because I know how to run a business successfully. And that includes not giving away thousands of pounds unnecessarily. Like, I said, I have my own charities I support, so thank you and good day.”

“But, if you could just spare us anything at all, it would make our residents so much more-”

“I said good day.” I folded my arms and stared at him.

“I see,” Nick said, his eyes going from me to Bobbi. “How do you work for someone so rude?”

Bobbi simply smiled at him and ignored the question.

“Good day to you, then,” Nick said, turning on his heel. “Merry fucking Christmas.”

“I didn’t know you supported any charities,” Bobbi said as the man slammed the door shut behind him.

“You didn’t know I had a brother. You didn’t know I supported charities.” I raised an eyebrow at her. “You don’t know much, do you? Do you know how to keep your mouth shut and do your job?”

Bobbi’s eyes went down to the desk. “I do, Mr Scrogie. There was something I wanted to ask you, although I’m not sure it’s the right time.”

“Go ahead.” I rolled my eyes. “What is it this time?”

“I wanted to perhaps buy my boyfriend one more present,” Bobbi asked nervously. “So I wondered if you might let me leave an hour or two early?”

“I didn’t know you had a boyfriend,” I crossed my arms, examining her for any signs of a lie.

“We’ve only been going out a couple of months.” Bobbi smiled hopefully.

“And I suppose you want paying for these couple of hours of shopping too?” I grumbled, trying not to imagine my young receptionist getting fucked by some equally young man. “As well as me having to pay you for not working Christmas Day?”

“You don’t have to,” Bobbi replied but I cut her off.

“Of course I have to,” I said. “Otherwise you’ll be going around telling everyone what a mean boss you’ve got and I don’t need my name besmirching any more than it already is.”

“You should maybe let some of the workers go early too,” Bobbi got up, slipping her coat on over her slim frame. “A little good will can go a long way, you know?”

“When I want business advice from a nineteen year old, I’ll ask for it,” I scowled at the young woman as she wrapped her scarf around her neck. “Now go before I change my mind.”

“Merry Christmas, Mr Scrogie.” Bobbi gave me a pretty smile as she left.

“Bah, humbug,” I snorted in derision after she’d left. I walked to the doors into the warehouse, looking through at the twenty-eight employees I had here, packing our produce into boxes ready to be shipped out with the last truck tonight. Should I let them go early? Was Bobbi right?

I gave myself a shake. What was I thinking? Of course Bobbi wasn’t right. She was a young kid who knew nothing about business.

The phone rang. Crap. I hated being my own receptionist, but I couldn’t lose a potential customer, so I picked it up and dealt with it. The shame of having to do it myself bothered me but the company came first. The company made money and money makes the world go around. Business always came first. I always did what had to be done.

Closing time approached and on a moment of impulse, I decided to let the workers go fifteen minutes early.

“Make sure you’re here all the earlier on Boxing Day,” I told them over the tannoy as they left and then after the last one had gone, I locked up after then and took one last look up at the sign above the door before I walked away.

Paul Scrogie and Marlene Jacobs, it read. Why was Marlene so on my mind today? Again, I gave myself a shake and wrapped my coat that bit tighter around me, buttoning up the top button. It was a cold, snowy night and despite what Bobbi had once said about me, I did feel the cold, just like everyone else.

I walked the short distance to my home. When I lived with Bella, we had a house in the suburbs but I’d sold it to escape the memories and bought a place nearer the factory and the warehouse. It was comforting to be able to look out of the front bedroom window and see both of my business buildings.

Even though it was only half a mile, my toes were bitterly cold from trudging through the steadily-deepening snow. I had a car. I had two, in fact,

but there was no need to waste money on fuel when I lived so close to the businesses, however I did feel some regret at not driving today when I finally reached my front door because my fingers were so cold that I couldn't work through the keys on my keyring to get the right one and put it in the lock.

Then I jumped back from the door in shock.

For a moment, my door-knocker, made from wrought iron in the shape of a lion's face was instead the face of Marlene; her eyes staring right into mine.

When I looked again, it was a lion. It had always been a lion. I was seeing things.

"You stupid old man," I chastised myself, finally getting my frozen fingers to work enough to place the right key in the lock and turn it.

"You stupid old man," Marlene's voice echoed back at me out of the snowy sky.

As soon as I had the door open, I leapt through into the house and locked the door behind me. What was going on?

The house was almost as cold as it was outside. I didn't waste money by leaving the heating on while I was out, but I put it on now and went into the kitchen to make myself a hot cup of tea.

Just as I did, there came an almighty bang from behind me and again I jumped almost out of my skin. When I turned, I realised it was the cellar door slamming shut. I must have left it open this morning and a peculiar draught - perhaps from me opening and closing the front door so quickly - had blown it shut.

Just to be on the safe side, I did a full patrol of the house, checking in every room but there was nothing out of the ordinary. No burglars to be found. No signs of forced entry. Everything was fine. I didn't know why I was so jumpy tonight. Something just felt off.

As I sat down on the edge of my bed, reaching across to my bedside cabinet to pick up the TV remote and put something on to watch, I heard another strange bump from downstairs.

“It’s probably just air in the radiators,” I said to myself. There wasn’t any point in going back downstairs to check. I’d locked the door. Everything was secure. Christmas Eve was a boring time with little to do - as was Christmas Day - so I’d just spend it lounging around, watching television and eating to pass the time until business returned on Boxing Day and life got back to normal.

I settled myself on the bed, watching a film but my eyelids felt heavy. I closed them for a moment, allowing myself to begin to drift to sleep but just as I did, I heard another bump. Then another. Then the cellar door boomed again and now I sat up, feeling alarmed. More bumps and now another sound, the clanking sound of metal, like chains being dragged across the floor. More noises; this time footsteps - yes, definitely footsteps - coming up the stairs.

I sat there, frozen in fear, wondering what to do as the bedroom door swung open.

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Chapter 2

“This can’t be,” I gasped, looking at the figure that walked into my bedroom. It was a woman, as tall, curvaceous and as bold in death as she had been in life.

“It can be, and it is,” the hallucination said to me, for that was what it must be. Some kind of hallucination. The bitter December chill must have gotten into my brain.

I gazed at the strange sight before me. Marlene’s red hair seemed to float as though on a breeze that wasn’t there and her dark-grey dress - she always wore grey - seemed to flutter similarly. I noted that she seemed to glow faintly blue and that she was semi-transparent. I could see the buttons on the back of her dress clearly through her torso.

“What do you want?” I asked, moving further away until my back was pressed against the headboard of my bed.

“With you?” Marlene replied, her voice as ghostly as her appearance. “Much. I have much to tell you.”

The ghost raised her arms and I saw that it had indeed been chains that I heard as she climbed the stairs. Long, heavy chains, which were wrapped around her arms and legs.

“These chains I forged in life,” she moaned. “Every link I forged by my actions. I would not have you do the same, Paul.”

“You call me by my name,” I said. “Do you know me?”

This couldn’t be Marlene. Marlene was dead, to begin with.

“Of course, I know you,” the ghost rolled its eyes. “It’s me. Marlene.”

“No.” I shook my head. “You’re a hallucination. You’re a product of some bad food I ate today or yesterday. You’re a bad dream. A nightmare that started the moment I laid down upon this bed and fell asleep without knowing.”

“Whether this be a dream or not,” Marlene stepped closer to me. “It is real. Right now, in this moment, I am here. As are you. And I will have you listen to me.”

“Don’t come any closer,” I barked, trying to collect my senses. “You’re scaring me. I can’t and won’t listen to you if I’m scared.”

Marlene sat on the end of the bed, looking at me the whole time. She was good-looking. She always had been. We’d been attracted to each other from the start and had ended up in a long, drawn-out affair, all those years ago, when times were good.

“I loved you, Paul,” she said slowly. “My spirit still does. This isn’t the first time I’ve sat here, watching you. Many days and nights I’ve spent invisible by your side in the seven years since I died.”

I shivered, not from the cold, but from that thought. “But tonight you’ve decided to show yourself to me. Why?”

“Since that day, when I died, you’ve been forging yourself chains - just as heavy as mine. You’ve worked hard on them. Because of my love for you, I’ve wanted to show myself to you for a long time, but why now? That, I am not allowed to tell.”

“Why didn’t you go to heaven?” I asked. “You were a good person, Marlene. A fantastic businesswoman. Why do you still linger here?”

“I put business first,” Marlene’s ghost replied, her large chest heaving with the words. For a moment, I found myself remembering her body - those large round breasts, her sweet pussy - then my focus was snapped back to the present as she shifted closer to me on the bed. “I never let my heart or

my spirit travel. I never told anyone that I loved them - not even you, though I did, more than anyone else. Because my spirit never travelled in life, it is cursed to travel in death. I am trapped here, bound by chains of my own making, condemned to stay on this dark Earth forever.”

“This is a nightmare,” I repeated to myself. “I’ll wake up in a minute and laugh at myself for believing any of it. I was thinking of you today and so now, I’m dreaming of you. That’s all it is.”

“Listen to me,” Marlene snapped. “I don’t have much time. I’m here to save you, Paul.”

“I don’t need saving,” I glared at the apparition. “I’m doing very well for myself. I’m happy. Now leave me be.”

“I will leave when it's time,” Marlene stood again, dragging the chains behind her as she walked back and forth across the bedroom. “You might tell yourself that you’re happy, but you’re not. Do you remember the nights we spent in bed, Paul? Making love. Laughing. Celebrating. Do you remember?”

“I remember being happy at how much money we were making,” I conceded. “The sex that followed and the relationship we had, it all came from the euphoria of being successful together. Didn’t it?”

Marlene considered me with sadness evident in her glowing blue eyes. “It was more than that - for me, at least. I knew joy then. I wish I’d told you that I loved you, Paul. I wish I’d been able to say those words back then, when they mattered.”

“You are saying them now,” I replied, suddenly feeling sorry for the spirit of my long-dead partner. “That is better than never.”

“And does it warm your heart?” she said with a sorrowful smile.

“Perhaps.” I felt uncomfortable, discussing my feelings with someone dead and gone. “If it is worth anything, Marlene, I cared about you. I miss you. Even today, seven years since your passing.”

“If you care about me, Paul, if you ever did - then listen to my words.” Marlene sat once again on the edge of the bed. “You can be spared the fate that awaited me. I can give you a chance and a hope of something better.”

“You were always a good friend to me,” I replied, watching Marlene once again look at the heavy chains that bound her arms and feet.

“I wanted to be more than a friend, but never had the opportunity in life,” she replied. “But now, in death, perhaps I can be at least that good friend one more time. Tonight, you will be haunted by three more spirits.”

“Three more spirits?” I moaned. “No. Please. Just let me go back to sleep and awake tomorrow with fonder memories of you.”

“Sleep, you will,” Marlene nodded. “But these three spirits are the only hope you have of casting off your chains, Paul. The first one will visit you at midnight.”

She stood up and walked to the window, which was somehow opened. The curtains blew inwards, a shower of snowflakes cascading across the room with them from outside.

“It is time for me to go,” Marlene said. “But this is not the last you will see of me. Come here, before I go.”

I stood up unsteadily from the bed and hesitantly made my way over to the window. Marlene gazed outside and my eyes followed.

“What the fuck?” I gasped.

The street outside my home was filled with phantoms. Some of which I even recognised from doing business deals with them years ago. Old men that I’d had dealings with who had died, they walked the streets, groaning desperately over the sounds of the heavy iron chains they dragged behind them. Some of the spirits were even linked, obviously their chains were forged together, perhaps working together, as Marlene and I had.

“When I die,” I asked the red-haired apparition standing next to me. “Will we be chained together?”

“I hope not, Paul,” she smiled. Then she bent forward and kissed me on the lips, a freezing cold touch that made my jaw ache for some reason. “That is what I am trying to save you from.”

Before I could say anything else, Marlene looked out of the window once more and from her mouth she groaned in the same fashion as the ghosts outside. Then her feet lifted from the floor and I watched in amazement as she drifted out through my window before turning to me one last time.

“Merry Christmas,” the floating ghost of my ex-partner said to me.

Then she disappeared into the air, like steam rising from a kettle.

I looked out of the window but everything was back to normal. The street was covered in snow, illuminated by the yellowish glow of the street lights outside. Footprints dotted across the white in trails where people had walked, each trail ending at a different house’s front door.

There were no spirits, nor any marks in the snow where their chains had dragged so noisily across the pavements. I had imagined it all. I needed to sleep. Whatever it was that was making me have this hallucination, the best way to recover from it, was to sleep it off.

Or if this was some bizarre nightmare, perhaps going to sleep would allow me to wake.

Marlene was dead. I’d been thinking about her today for some reason. Perhaps in recognition that I had cared for her - more than I ever told her. We’d never celebrated a Christmas together. Back then, Christmas had been about Bella and Tim; my family. Marlene’s death had been the end of that but I wasn’t ready to go through those memories. Not yet.

I closed the window and drew the curtains, before laying back down on the bed and ignoring the television that was still playing, I closed my eyes and instantly fell asleep.

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Chapter 3

For some reason, I was awoken by the sound of a clock I didn't own.

Ding-dong, it chimed.

I sat up, listening to the sound repeat. And then repeat again. What the fuck?

I got up out of bed, trying to shake the weird dream that I'd just had from my head. I'd dreamt of Marlene, as a ghost, telling me some weird story that I'd be visited by three spirits and some other nonsense.

Ding-dong.

Where was the sound coming from? I didn't own anything that made that sort of noise. I had an alarm clock on my bedside table but that buzzed and was only set at 6.00am, to get me up nice and early for work every morning.

Ding-dong.

I walked out of the bedroom and onto the landing, listening to the noise over and over, trying to figure out where it was coming from, but the sound seemed to simply reverberate in the air all around me. Was I still asleep?

When it chimed for the twelfth and final time, I stayed still on the landing for a moment then walked back into the bedroom and looked at my alarm clock. It was midnight.

Marlene had said that the first spirit would visit me at...

Creak.

There was a noise behind me and I turned to see the bedroom curtains opened once more. This time, there was no Marlene - no faintly glowing apparition of a long-dead partner. Instead, there was a young girl, perhaps the same age as Bobbi, with flowing pale hair the colour of the snow outside. Her form - the outline of her - seemed to shimmer, as though I was looking at her through a lens made of shifting water.

“Are you the first spirit?” I asked, realising I must still be dreaming.

“I am,” the young girl smiled at me.

“Who are you?” I said, my legs suddenly turning weak. “I don’t know you.”

“I am the Ghost of Christmas Past,” she raised a hand and a beam of blue light seemed to spread from it, lighting the bedroom with its ethereal glow. “Come with me.”

“Come with you where?” I said. I’d slumped onto the bed but as she reached out to me, I felt my legs grow stronger and I stood up for a reason unknown.

“To your past Christmases, of course,” the apparition giggled, then reached forward and took my hand.

Her touch was warm. I’d expected it to be cold, like Marlene’s kiss, but it wasn’t. The blue light went out and we were thrown into darkness, as though I had closed my eyes and when they were reopened, we were somewhere totally different.

“Where are we?”

“Don’t you recognise it?” the Ghost of Christmas Past said as she led me through a night-darkened car park into a pub, which was full of partying people; the air pulsating with pop music.

“That’s me,” I replied, stopping dead as we weaved through the crowd. “Look at me. I’m so young.”

It was me. I was in my twenties and suddenly the memory of where I was - and when this was - came drifting back to me.

“It’s Christmas Eve,” the ghost said, pointing at me. I was sitting on a bar stool - all on my own - drinking a beer and I remembered.

“This is the night I met Bella,” I recalled. “I went out on my own because I didn’t have any proper friends back then. I was fresh out of university and just about to set up my first business but right at this point-” I stopped because the memory was surprisingly painful.

“At this point, you had no one.” The ghost nodded, her young, pretty face looking sad for me. “You were always the loner, Paul. You never let your spirit travel because you were scared to. You were shy. Introverted.”

“Here comes Bella,” I said, smiling at the sight. An attractive blonde woman had noticed me sitting all alone and took pity on me. She walked over, leaving her friends behind and sat on the stool next to mine.

“Hello,” I saw her say. I couldn’t hear the words because we were too far away and the music was too loud but I didn’t need to hear the words. I knew them off by heart. I’d never forgotten them. “I’d really like a drink and I have no money. You look like you could use some company so why don’t you treat me in return for me joining you?”

The ghost and I watched this young version of Paul Scrogie smile shyly and reply hesitantly, asking Bella what she’d like to drink, then the world went dark again.

I didn’t need to watch any further. I knew what had happened. We’d got drunk and I’d ended up having my first kiss that very night. We exchanged numbers and went on a date after the festive period was over and we never looked back.

“Bella,” I sighed as the world around me shimmered back into existence. It was the following Christmas Eve - the best Christmas of my life - and we were having sex in the middle of a field. I looked around. The sun shone brightly - this was an unusually warm winter - but in this ghostly world, I

couldn't feel its warmth. We were in the countryside, our car and the remains of a discarded picnic nearby.

I remembered. We did this often. We'd drive out of the city, spend all day together in the hills, sometimes just walking and talking, sometimes doing this - making passionate love under the blue skies. I watched us have sex, enjoying the almost-forgotten sight of Bella's slim body; her soft, pale skin and modest breasts; the fine thatch of blonde hair that covered her young mound which I loved parting with my fingers so that I could delve my tongue inside. Then I watched as I rammed my cock into her hard and fast before cumming deep inside her. This was the time we'd conceived our child. She'd accidentally gotten pregnant after missing her contraceptive pill and another nine months after this, Bella would give birth to our son, Tim.

We were married the year following that and we were so blissfully happy that my heart ached at the memories. Then the world disappeared back into the void, before reappearing from the darkness and again it was Christmas Eve, but this was a different one entirely. Twenty years later. Seven years ago.

"Do you know where we are now?" the ghost whispered from my side.

"Oh no," I groaned. "Don't show me this. Please don't show me this."

"I'm doing this for your own good," the young girl replied.

We were in the bedroom of our old house. I was on top of the bed, making love to the beautiful woman beneath me. But the woman wasn't Bella.

"Don't stop," Marlene moaned, her hands clutching at my backside, pulling me into her. "I want you to cum inside me."

"You shouldn't be seeing this," I reprimanded the ashen-haired apparition. "This is wrong."

"I see everything," the girl replied. "Everything. Everywhere. Everytime. There is nothing I haven't already seen."

I watched in horror from the side of the bed as Marlene and I switched positions. I noted the sweat dripping from my back and I even admired the vigour I had - just seven years ago, how I'd aged since - as I began to pound my red-haired business partner from behind. Her large breasts swayed beneath her as we fucked until eventually I pulled out, spraying my cum all over her round ass, some of it running down and sticking in the reddish pubic hair that sprouted from around her engorged pussy lips as she rolled over onto her back again, a huge smile on her face.

I knew what happened next and I cringed,

“What the fuck is going on here?” Bella said from the doorway.

It was Christmas Eve and Bella had pretended that she was going to her parents for the holidays this particular year. She'd been suspicious of Marlene and I since someone saw us kissing at our company Christmas party and had told her. I had no idea back then, of course, or I'd never have invited Marlene to spend Christmas with me that year. Marlene's ghost had reminded me that we never spent Christmas together - we almost did - but then, this happened.

I felt tears swelling in my eyes as the subsequent fight ensued. Marlene hurriedly got dressed and left, but she'd been drinking with me all day and I should never have let her get into the car and drive home.

I didn't know until the following morning but she never made it home. Her car swerved from the road and hit a tree. Marlene died instantly.

The world shimmered, time skipping forward to just the next day.

“I'm so sorry,” I sobbed, seeing Bella sitting on our sofa next to me. Again, I remembered this conversation so I didn't need to listen but the ghost gave me no choice.

“You either sell the business, demand that Marlene sells her share or I leave,” Bella issued the ultimatum to me. At this point, we still didn't know that Marlene was dead, her mangled body laid in the morgue, her ghost already freed, laden down with those dreaded chains.

“The business is everything,” I replied. “I can’t sell it. What will we do for money?”

“We have enough money to live on for the rest of our lives,” Bella responded. “You can’t expect me to remain married to you when I’ve just discovered you’re having an affair with your business partner. Either she goes, you go, or I go.”

I loved Bella. I loved Marlene too, in my own way but what Bella and I had was special. It was that first love that actually goes on to survive. A pure, undiluted, unspoilt love. I didn’t see it at the time. I didn’t recognise it or appreciate its value until later.

“Why didn’t I choose her?” I said to myself, making the ghost look at me. “I chose the business. I was so stupid. I was so vain to think she’d stay with me for the money.”

“She did, for a while,” the young apparition replied.

“No,” I corrected her. “I told her I wouldn’t be given an ultimatum. I offered her an apology and a promise to never sleep with Marlene again but it wasn’t enough. Bella left that day with Tim and never came back.”

“You don’t understand,” the ghost said softly, taking my hand in hers and again, I marvelled at how warm her touch was for a phantom. “Let me show you another Christmas. One before this. One you won’t remember because it holds a secret that until now, you didn’t know.”

The world disappeared once more and although I didn’t know it at that moment, everything I thought I did know - my entire relationship history - was about to be turned upside down.

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Chapter 4

“Where are we?” I asked as a new, unfamiliar, surrounding rematerialised around us.

“This is your seventh Christmas together with Bella,” the Ghost of Christmas Past informed me. “Do you remember it?”

“I can’t remember every single Christmas,” I responded, looking around. “I don’t know this place.”

We were in a hotel bedroom but not one I ever remembered staying in. Bella was laying on the bed in just a fluffy white bathrobe. She looked beautiful. Her long blonde hair was damp as though she’d had a shower but was still styled in waves while her face was glowing, fresh-faced and makeup free. How I loved her, I thought to myself. Why did I ever cheat on her? I hurt her so much.

“You don’t remember the year when Bella got stuck in the snow driving home on Christmas Eve?” the young apparition asked me.

“I do,” I said slowly, trying to understand. That would indeed be around seven years or so into our relationship. Bella had travelled north to see her brother and was on her way back when a storm had struck the afternoon on Christmas Eve and by early evening she’d had to pull off the motorway, choosing to stay in a hotel rather than risk travelling through the thickening snow. It meant us missing Christmas morning together but it was better than risking her being stranded or worse still, having an accident.

Then I realised the shower was running. Had she forgotten to turn it off? My question was answered as the sound of running water stopped.

“I’m sorry you have to see this,” the ghost whispered, as a man - someone I’d never seen before, walked out of the bathroom. He was dark-haired and handsome with a very hairy chest and he was also completely naked. A long flaccid penis swung around between his legs as he climbed onto the bed next to my then-wife.

“What’s going on?” I asked the young figure standing at my side. “I don’t understand.”

“This is what really happened that night. Watch,” the ghost replied.

“I can’t believe I’m actually doing this,” I heard Bella say, then I watched as instructed as she took off the bathrobe to reveal that she too, was totally naked. She’d trimmed the small triangle of golden pubes between her legs to a tidy landing-strip, which I also remember as happening around the same time, although she’d never explained why she’d done it. Now I knew, she’d shaved to impress this man, whoever he was.

The man slid down the bed, burying his face into her pussy and I had to look away because the sight was unbearable.

“No.” The young girl took my hand and pulled my arm, turning me back around. “You need to watch. You need to see.”

I ignored her and kept my eyes shut, listening to Bella’s moans. “I can’t watch. This didn’t happen. You’re lying. This isn’t real.”

“That night, Bella met this man - his name is Matt - in the hotel bar,” the ghost told me. “They were both staying at the hotel alone that night. They’d never met before but they got talking. He bought her dinner and drinks and then he talked her into coming to his hotel room. Then this happened. Watch, Paul. You need to see.”

The room was quiet. Bella wasn’t moaning so I opened my eyes to see why. Now she was sucking his cock. It had been impressive soft and was equally as imposing now it was hard.

“No. Please, no,” I whimpered as he moved, positioning himself over my ex-wife and then sinking his long, thick erection inside her. “Please spirit. Stop. Tell me this didn’t happen.”

“It happened,” she replied softly. “They had sex all night. But if you truly don’t want to see more, we can move forward. Two years.”

The stranger was fucking Bella hard and fast now and for some reason I couldn’t take my eyes off the scene in front of me until the room suddenly shimmered and was once again cast into darkness.

“What happened two years later?” I asked, fearing the apparition’s answer.

“This,” she replied.

We were now in our bedroom. Bella was on our bed, naked, playing with her pussy. Another stranger, short and much older than her was laying next to her, watching her.

“Who is that?” I asked.

“One of Bella’s many lovers,” the ghost answered. “You were at work. You worked such long hours. She grew bored. That night of impulsive love making at the hotel awakened something in her. It made her feel desired. You put the business before her. She needed love so she went out and got it.”

The older man grew tired of watching and moved Bella’s hand, ramming his own fingers inside her and fingering her hard and roughly until Bella orgasmed, her back arching as she convulsed.

“Now fuck me,” she told him, so he did. I watched, feeling the hurt inside me grow with every thrust until the ghost moved us onwards once more.

“How many?” I asked. “How many lovers did she take?”

“I can’t answer you precisely,” the spirit answered as the room shimmered into darkness. “I can see only Christmases past. But I know it was many. Very many.”

Then the room coalesced once more. We were once again in our bedroom and this time Bella was making love to a different man - a dark-skinned man with an athletic body. We skipped forward again. Another man, then another. I was shown lover after lover after lover all enjoying Bella. The woman I'd loved so much.

"Why torment me so?" I cried out. "Enough!"

"One last Christmas for you," the spirit said, relenting to my request for mercy.

The air solidified again into somewhere I recognised. A time I recognised.

"Fred's house," I said, looking around at the living room I was standing in. My brother was there, as was his wife, Helen, with their baby - my nephew - in her arms. "The year before Marlene died. The last Christmas that Bella and I were happy."

"Bella wasn't happy," the spirit whispered. "Were you? Truly? Watch."

Bella and I were there, dancing to the Christmas music playing on the television. I remembered this party. Fred and I would often get together during the festive season. Our parties were good. We were family but this was the last time we celebrated together. It all stopped when Marlene died and Bella left me.

There were others there too. Bella's cousin and Helen's brother and his wife were there too, dancing and chatting, all full of festive spirit. I watched as Bella broke away from my dance. "I need the bathroom," she said with a smile and a kiss on my cheek.

I watched myself sit on the sofa, Helen's grey-haired sibling sitting next to me and speaking to me about something or other.

"Follow Bella," the spirit murmured.

"To the bathroom?" I queried.

"Yes."

I walked upstairs, the Ghost of Christmas Past trailing behind me but the bathroom door was closed.

“The door is locked,” I turned to the pale-haired spirit when I tried the handle and it didn’t budge.

“Walk through,” she replied, pushing me sharply in the back so that I glided - rather disconcertingly - straight through the wooden door onto the other side.

To my abject horror, Bella wasn’t alone in the bathroom. Fred - my own brother, my own flesh-and-blood, was there too, pressing her against the white-tiled wall and kissing her.

I watched, feeling doubly-betrayed, as he reached under her black skirt and tugged down her white panties, then undid his zipper and drew out his average-sized dick.

“Fuck me,” Bella panted, turning so that she was facing the wall.

I saw his penis slide into her from behind, then he grabbed her hips and screwed her fast and hard, at one point clasping a hand over her mouth to stifle her moans.

“Cum inside me,” I heard Bella say, muffled against his palm. “I love it when you cum in me.”

After he’d finished and Bella pulled her panties up, he leaned against the door, so she couldn’t leave just yet. “Are you going to let him fuck you tonight?” my brother asked. “I like it when you let him while my cum is still in you.”

“Me too,” Bella giggled. “He doesn’t have a clue. I might even make him go down on me.”

“You’re evil,” Fred grinned.

“No, I’m not,” Bella replied, seeming to take the accusation literally. “He’s ignored me for years. We have sex but even when we do, I can tell his mind

is on work. It's always work. He ignores me, he ignores Tim. I've tried talking to him about it but he doesn't care. To him, business is everything."

"You should leave him," Fred replied. "You only stay because of the money."

"Not true," Bella corrected him. "I stay with him because I feel sorry for him. I don't care about his money. He idolised me once. But now I've been replaced by another idol. Wealth. The pursuit of wealth. No. I only stay with him because I pity him."

As much as seeing Bella fuck all those different men had hurt me, that sentence hurt me more. It cut me so deeply, I felt a tear roll down my cheek.

The reason she left me wasn't because I'd hurt her. It was because I'd destroyed the only thing that kept her with me. She no longer pitied me once she knew I'd been fucking Marlene. She probably felt stupid for staying all those years with me, wasting herself on me, feeling guilty for cheating on me when she needn't have - because I'd been doing the same to her.

"This changes everything," I whispered into the air as Fred finally moved out of the way so they could leave the bathroom. As they walked out onto the landing, giggling together, we followed them, watching them walk down the stairs together.

"Look," the ghost said, pointing towards a darkened bedroom doorway in front of us.

I looked and saw Fred's wife, Helen, standing there, her hands held to her mouth as though to quieten the sobs that wracked her body.

"She saw them," I gasped in shock.

"She did," the young spirit replied. Then the room shimmered and finally, we were back in my own bedroom, standing beside my bed.

“But she didn’t leave Fred,” I muttered, still trying to absorb everything I’d just seen. “She must have known they had sex. Being in the bathroom together and the noises they made. Walking out laughing, like they did.”

“She knows,” the young spirit nodded, her dark eyes boring into mine. “Why she never confronted her or Fred, I do not know. It’s up to you what you do with that knowledge.”

“Why did you show me?” I said, my voice cracking with emotion. “You’ve destroyed my past. The only happy memories I had are spoiled.”

“You blame yourself for losing Bella,” the phantom smiled gently. “You thought you’d hurt an innocent woman, but she wasn’t innocent at all. She may have had just reason for doing what she did and you might be no better for sleeping with Marlene, but she wasn’t innocent. Remember that.”

“So many men,” I said to myself, thinking of all the lovers that Bella had taken. I’d only ever slept with Marlene. “It’s not fair.”

“I know. My time is gone,” the spirit answered. “I must leave you. Another shall come soon but for now, think on what you’ve seen.”

“No more, please,” I asked, stepping towards the girl but she moved away, her form dissipating like a wind blowing through a pile of feathers. Only her voice remained.

“Sleep, Paul Scrogie,” she said. “There are more truths yet and you must rest.”

I slumped backwards onto my bed, alone once more. The multiple breakings of my heart had exhausted me, emotionally and physically.

I closed my eyes and slept.

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Chapter 5

I was awoken yet again by the chiming of a clock I didn't have but the sound disappeared as soon as I opened my eyes and I realised again that I'd been dreaming. Hopefully this time, I really had awoken.

The air in my bedroom was cool and crisp and as I sat up and switched the bedside lamp on, I saw my breath billow out as steam.

"Why is it so cold?" I said to myself, rubbing my hands together. I was sure I'd turned the heating on before I came up to bed. As I went downstairs to check the thermostat was working correctly, I also realised I was still fully-dressed. I remembered laying down on the bed to watch some TV and relax. I must have dropped off.

I turned the temperature up one degree. That should trigger the heating into warming the house up somewhat. It was cold outside, but the house wasn't usually this cold. As I passed one of the radiators, I put a hand on it, then hastily pulled it away because it was red-hot.

"Weird," I said, once again noticing my breath fogging as I spoke.

As I walked upstairs again to return to my bedroom, I noticed something even more weird. The door to the spare bedroom was closed but a pale amber glow was shimmering underneath it, as though a light were on inside. I was sure I hadn't left the lights on in there - besides, the lighting was white, not this strange yellow colour that gleamed through the crack between the door and floor.

Could it be a fire? The way the light shimmered and its colour suggested so. I pushed the door open carefully, then stepped back in shock at what lay inside.

The bedroom was my spare room but rather than it be the sparsely decorated interior that I was used to - with a plain double bed and wardrobe and not very much else - instead, it was decorated with holly and mistletoe wreaths along the walls and a large open fireplace had appeared beside them, with a blazing log fire crackling away, illuminating the room.

“Come in, man!” boomed a voice from the far corner, making me turn my head in amazement at what I was seeing “Come in and get to know me better!”

A huge man sat in a large wooden throne opposite me. By huge, I meant massive. He stood up, beckoning me forward and his head bumped against the ceiling, making him laugh out loud - a deep, jolly laugh like nothing I’d ever heard before.

“Who are you?” I said, fear growing in my stomach at the sheer presence of the intruder.

“I’m the Ghost of Christmas Present, my friend,” he said, looming over me and grasping my hand in his to shake it. I looked up at him, all seven-foot-plus of him, noticing that he was as almost as wide as he was tall, with a thick neck, arms and legs and a belly that Santa Claus himself would be proud of. He was wearing a long, green robe which flapped open at the front, exposing a bare chest covered in red hair as thick as the mop on his head and a fiery beard that hung down from his broad chin.

“Am I dreaming again?” I pinched myself on the arm when he finally released me from his grip.

“Perhaps life itself is a dream,” the giant mused, then laughed loudly again and his robe flapped open further as he did.

“Cover yourself, spirit.” I said, looking away in disgust because this time I could see everything, including the enormous penis swinging down between his thighs.

“Perhaps you should cover yourself?” The giant pointed downwards with a white-toothed grin on his face and I covered my groin in horror as I realised

I was naked.

“What happened to my clothes?” I asked, feeling my face growing red.
“Give them back to me.”

“We’re all born naked,” the giant said and shrugged. “There’s no shame in being naked. I’m the Ghost of Christmas Present. I see everything. I see beyond clothes, beyond wealth or poverty, beyond pretence, beyond lies. I see your heart, Paul Scrogie and a small and wizened thing it is. Much like your penis.”

“For a Christmas spirit, you’re not very nice, are you?” I replied, glaring at him. I did have a small penis. I’d always known I was smaller than average. Bella had once measured it at four inches when erect, then tried to console me by saying that size didn’t matter, but I knew now that it did. The lovers I’d seen her with had all been more well endowed than I was. Marlene hadn’t seemed to mind. Perhaps she was just kinder than Bella. I would never know.

“I am nice to those that deserve niceness,” the giant replied. “My heart is large and that makes the rest of me large too - including my penis. Perhaps if you’d been nice, Scrogie, perhaps your own penis wouldn’t be so tiny.”

I kept my hand covering myself, feeling both shame and fury rush through me as he continued to laugh and make fun of me.

“It’s like a little Christmas pine cone,” he chuckled, holding his own long, fat dick in his hand as though to compare. “Whereas mine is more like a Yule Log.”

“Very funny,” I growled at him. “Is this the entire purpose of your visit tonight, spirit? To enjoy yourself at my expense?”

“No,” the ghost said, suddenly serious. “I have things to show you.”

“What things?”

“Why, Christmas, of course.” He held out his hand once more. “Take my hand. I don’t have long. I exist for but one day a year and this day will soon be gone.”

I put my hand in his, grateful that it was the hand that hadn’t been holding his arm-sized cock a moment before.

The room disappeared, much like it had with the previous spirit, but when it rematerialised, we weren’t in the past. The sun was just rising over the horizon, colouring the dark-purple sky with streaks of gold and blue and lighting the snow-covered rooftops of a row of terraced houses. We were in a small cul-de-sac; an area I recognised as being just a few miles away from the factory.

“Follow me,” the spirit whispered - even his whisper was louder than my natural speaking tone, such was the size of the fellow - and so I did, tracing his steps through the deep snow, wondering why I couldn’t feel the cold on my bare feet or anywhere else on my naked form.

We walked through a plain white front door (a most disconcerting experience) and into a small and poorly decorated house, then slowly, we treaded up the narrow staircase.

“Where are you taking me?” I asked. “It’s so early. Who are we here to see?”

“Come. Watch,” was all the spirit said as we walked through an open door into a plain and simple bedroom.

Bobbi was sitting on the bed, looking like she’d just awoken because her almost-black hair was messed up from sleep and she rubbed her large brown eyes as she looked at the small pile of gifts in front of her. She was wearing a white t-shirt and nothing else and I couldn’t help but look at her attractive, shapely, chocolate-coloured legs as she crossed them.

“Merry Christmas,” said the man sitting next to her. I’d never seen him before. He was young; around the same age as Bobbi probably, with short, fair hair and a tanned complexion. He was handsome and his body was

impressive, toned shoulders and arms with an impressive midsection and bulging abdominal muscles. He watched, as did I, as Bobbi opened her presents one by one. Perfume, a hat, a scarf, a watch and then finally a lovely pair of diamond earrings.

“Oh, Zac,” she threw her slender arms around the athletic man and squeezed him tight. “I love them. You’re amazing. Thank you so much.”

“I love you,” he shrugged. “I’d give you the world, if I could.”

“I know,” my young clerk replied with a smile. Then she reached beneath the bed and pulled out three small presents which she passed to her boyfriend. “I wish I could have afforded more for you, but...”

“But your boss is a tight, miserable bastard who doesn’t pay you enough,” her boyfriend replied as he opened his gifts. She’d bought him aftershave, a scarf and a computer game, all of which made him break out into a huge grin. “Bobbi, these are great. You shouldn’t have.”

“Like I said, I wish I could have spent more on you,” she sighed. “But yeah, old man Scrogie is tight-fisted.”

“You should have left that job ages ago,” Zac replied. “You’re wasted there.”

“If I didn’t feel so sorry for him, I would.” Bobbi shrugged. “Despite him being a stingy asshole, I like him, even though I shouldn’t. I don’t know - it’s like I see some good in him - despite everyone else hating him.”

“Anyway,” Zac grinned mischievously, “Let’s not talk about that miserable old dick. Let’s talk about us.”

“And your lovely young dick,” Bobbi grinned back wickedly.

“Ah, young love,” said the giant from next to me as Zac slid down his shorts to reveal an average-sized but very hard penis while Bobbi lifted her t-shirt up over her head. My eyes felt like they were bulging out of my head because her body was incredible. Her tits were firm with youth, perfectly

round and of a bigger-than-a-handful size, which surprised me as I'd thought she was smaller busted. Her nipples were small and dark and stood out prominently as Zac bent his neck and took one in his mouth, making Bobbi moan.

"I think we should go," I said to the giant who was watching as avidly as I was.

"We can linger a moment longer," he replied cheerfully and I noticed his unnaturally large penis was erect now, standing out in front of him like a spear. "Do you remember what it was like to be young, Paul?"

"I do," I said, watching Bobbi open her legs so that Zac could slip a finger inside her tiny hairless slit. I felt my own cock grow hard too. I did remember being young. That ability to love and to live - almost carefree - it seemed like a very long time ago now.

We watched as Bobbi sucked Zac, taking his length all the way into her throat before giving him a surprisingly well-practiced blow job for a girl her age. I felt a huge swell of jealousy which only grew stronger when he eased Bobbi back onto the bed and slid his cock into her.

As they fucked with all the passion and vigour of teenagers, I looked at the presents, discarded by our feet and the disparity between her gifts and his.

"Do they really think me a stingy old bastard?" I asked the spirit, feeling a surge of guilt.

"They do," the giant replied, then finally deciding that we'd seen enough, he waved a hand and we were plunged into darkness once more.

"Take me back," I implored with him. "Let me meet this final spirit and get it over and done with. I've seen enough. I've learned my lesson. I know I'm mean but that is part of being good at business. I know I'm old and perhaps I let the envy of youth turn me bitter. Is that what you're trying to teach me?"

“But you have more to see,” the jolly red-haired spirit replied, raising a meaty hand and when he lowered it, we were somewhere new yet again. Now we were in a another bedroom, but this one was much better decorated than Bobbi’s humble house.

“Bella,” I sighed, seeing my ex-wife again. She was on top of the bed, naked, but the man on top of her, fucking her for all he was worth wasn’t any of the men I’d seen her with earlier. This man was black, his dark skin shining in the early morning light that razed in through the gap between the bedroom curtains.

“Her husband,” the spirit explained.

“Yes, fuck me. Make me cum one more time,” I heard Bella say. “Before the kids wake up.”

Her husband didn’t reply. He just grunted his assent and continued to pound my golden-haired ex-wife. The contrast between his dark skin and Bella’s pale complexion was startling and shockingly erotic.

“Bella is married and has children,” I commented, ignoring my weird arousal. “She’s moved on. Is she happy?”

“Very.” The spirit smiled. “You never moved on. Not truly. Sometimes, you have to let go and live in the present, not in the past.”

The room disappeared and then we were somewhere new. I smelled the surroundings before I saw them. Turkey. Roast Potatoes. Carrots. Gravy. The delicious aromas of cooking food wafted into my nostrils and I breathed them in, savouring the smell.

“Such a shame that Uncle Paul isn’t here to enjoy this, mommy,” said a little girl with light brown hair to her mother, who was stirring a saucepan on a stove.

I recognised her instantly as Helen, my sister-in-law. She was a good-looking woman, handsome rather than beautiful, with shoulder-length light brown hair and a kind face. Her piercing pale blue eyes were her most eye-

catching feature, although her healthy bust and round ass came a close second and third.

“It is a shame,” Helen replied. “Uncle Paul is a sad, lonely man and it might have cheered him up.”

“I don’t think anything could cheer up my brother,” Fred said as he strolled into the kitchen with my nephew in tow. “I don’t think he has any cheer in him anymore. He’s not a man. He’s an empty, hollow shell.”

“That’s a mean thing to say, daddy,” said the little girl. “Maybe he’s just sad like mommy says.”

“Your daddy misses him,” Helen said. “As much as he says otherwise.”

“I don’t miss him,” Fred shrugged, stealing some of the turkey before Helen could smack him on the back of the hand.

“Hey,” she said. “Don’t steal the meat. We couldn’t afford a big enough turkey this year, remember. There’s barely enough to go around us two adults, let alone the kids.”

“I’m sorry,” Fred replied, nodding sadly. “But as for Paul. He’s gone. He might as well be dead, for the amount of contact we have.”

“Don’t you care about him?” my niece asked.

“He doesn’t care about us,” Fred answered, a sad look in my brother’s eyes as he considered his daughter. “If he cared, he’d be here to finally meet you. But he doesn’t. So why should we care about him?”

“I do care,” I told the Ghost of Christmas Present as the scene vanished.

“Caring only matters if shown,” the red-bearded, half-naked ghost said softly. “Love only matters if shared.”

“Enough,” I pleaded. “Let me go home now. Everything you’re doing is making me feel worse and worse. Is that your intent? To make me feel bad? To punish me?”

“I’m showing you the truth,” the ghost informed me solemnly. “You had truths hidden from you in the past. But in the present, you hide the truths from yourself. Plain, obvious truths stare you in the face, but you deny them. You’ve been lied to before but now you lie to yourself, Paul Scrogie.”

“I don’t know what you mean.” I looked around, staring into the darkness, wondering where this was leading.

“Your girlfriend, Claire,” the giant replied. “You love her, although you don’t admit to it.”

“Perhaps I do,” I replied, even more confused. Why was he bringing Claire into it? So far, we hadn’t discussed Claire - the one good thing that I had in my life that wasn’t tainted by the tortuous revelations of tonight.

“She spends a lot of time away,” the spirit continued. “With friends and a family that you’ve never met. Do you know why?”

“I’m guessing you’re going to show me,” I said, one more ball of dread building in my stomach.

“I am,” the spirit’s voice boomed one last time. Then another bedroom materialised around us and I gasped in utter, utter horror at the sight before me.

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Chapter 6

I met Claire three years after Bella left. During that time, I'd been with a few women - it's easy to attract girls when everyone knows you're rich - but none of them had managed to retain my interest beyond us having sex the first or second time. But Claire was different. For a start, she reminded me of Bella. She was young, blonde and curvy with a nice figure and a good sense of humour. She could also make me smile, unlike anyone else I'd met since my ex-wife and Marlene. I'd actually taken my time with her - not rushing to get her in bed, unlike the previous women I'd dated - because I liked her so much on our first date and also she could handle my moods and gave me back every bit as much sarcasm and grumpiness as I could throw her way. That made me respect her and perhaps out of that respect, I didn't see her as just another woman to have sex with. I saw her as potentially more.

Three years later we were still together. During that time, I'd paid for her to have breast implants, making her even bustier than Bella was, and I was happy to provide enough money for her to go to the salon regularly - always keeping her hair, makeup and nails perfect. I liked having a stunning woman like her on my arm whenever we went anywhere.

Claire made me happy. Or at least she was the person who came closest to making me happy. We could be closer, but that was my fault. There was an age gap between us - I was over twenty years her senior - she was still in her twenties, so I sometimes felt guilty for that age gap along with the fact that she wanted children and I didn't. But, she'd stayed by my side and I loved her for that. Perhaps I didn't love her quite as much as Bella, but whereas Bella had refused to acknowledge the importance of my work, Claire accepted it and earned my gratitude for that.

She'd had a couple of boyfriends before me. She'd told me about them as candidly as I'd told her about Bella and Marlene, saying that they'd meant

nothing to her and that they weren't great lovers. She'd reassured me that my smaller penis and my age didn't matter either. She loved me and that was all that mattered. I reassured her that I'd never cheat on her as I'd done to Bella, but I hadn't been as open about my feelings for her like she had with me.

Love only matters when shared. That was what the Ghost of Christmas Present had said and I realised that this was my problem. I felt love but I couldn't show it or share it. Just as people didn't think I felt the cold because I never complained about it, they believed I didn't feel love because I never showed it.

Claire might not be Bella but I didn't want her to be, not really. I liked her for who and what she was: a woman with the backbone to stand up to me, who had earned my respect with her unswerving loyalty and ability to pull me out of my darker moods when I needed her to.

But now, even that was lost.

We were in a hotel room. My beloved Claire was on the bed in just some sexy red lingerie. Her breasts were flowing out of the bra, one nipple had already slipped free from the too-small cup and the other was threatening to join it at any moment. Her long, wavy blonde hair billowed out from her head onto the pillows around her and her face was gorgeous, bright red lipstick and smokey eyeshadow making her look like a Hollywood actress.

I'd always felt blessed to have her because she had the body of a pornstar. Those large breasts, her tight pussy always waxed to perfection with just a tiny landing strip. That Marilyn Monroe hair and face - all mine - even with my small cock and age-lined face and body, this gorgeous woman was mine and I knew I was the envy of all the men in the town where we lived. I also knew that lots of people commented that she was only with me for my money but I didn't care. She was with me and that's all I cared about. Those large breasts were mine. That outrageous curvy body was mine. Her immaculate pussy was mine.

Except the scene in front of me painted that to not be the case anymore because there were other people in the room. Not one man, but two. Both

much younger than me - one mixed-race with the body of a Maori warrior or something - all muscles and tattoos. The other man was slimmer, white and tall and stunningly good-looking with jet-black hair and stubble, looking every bit the Hollywood star that Claire did.

Both men were already naked and I looked in envy at their bodies and their cocks, both larger than me even just semi-erect like they were now. Claire set out to improve upon that, taking both men in her hands and beginning to stroke them sensually.

“What is going on?” I asked the Ghost of Christmas Present, who I glumly noticed was erect again as he watched my girlfriend prepare to cheat on me.

“This is Christmas Day. Today. Watch,” was all the giant said to me in reply.

“You’re sure your husband won’t find out about this?” the dark-skinned man said as Claire began to suck his cock while still wanking off the other man.

“I’m sure,” she replied, stopping almost as soon as she’d started sucking him. “I love my husband to bits - even though he thinks I’m only with him for his money, like most people do. But he’s so vanilla in bed. We’ve been together so long and he’s never so much as wanted to even try anal - or anything. We always do missionary position and that’s about it. He comes in five minutes. His dick is small. I love him and I don’t want to leave him but I need more than that.”

“So, you’ve done this before?” the white model-looking man asked, looking down at Claire’s hand rubbing his dick to its impressive full hardness.

“I do it once a month,” Claire shrugged, both hands working their cocks still. “I meet guys like you, from the internet, people who he doesn’t know and has no danger of ever knowing. Sometimes just one guy, sometimes two - like today.”

Then she began to suck the white model’s cock greedily and hungrily.

“Even on Christmas Day,” the tattooed man said.

“He thinks I’ve gone to see my family down south,” Claire mumbled around the large cock in her mouth. “I couldn’t stand facing Christmas with him this year. He hates Christmas. He hates everyone being happy. Well, I need happiness and nothing makes me happier than two nice, thick cocks.”

“I just feel uneasy. I mean this hotel is like half a mile from where you live,” the white model said in a raspy voice because Claire was going to town on his dick, licking up and down his shaft while fondling his shaved, hairless balls.

Half a mile away. I knew which hotel this was. The Plaza. It was the only hotel as nice as this that was within even five miles of our home. That made her cheating feel even worse. She was doing it almost on our own doorstep.

“That makes it more exciting for me,” Claire said, in-between switching cocks back to the mixed-race young man. “In some ways, I’d love him to catch me. The thought turns me on. Maybe he’d discover his kinky side and join in. Or even just stand in the corner and watch. That’d turn me on.”

“You are kinky,” the darker guy chuckled. “I like it.”

The model reached down and slid Claire’s panties down her thighs, shoving a finger inside her tight hole, sliding it in and out and making her moan around the brown cock in her mouth.

“Claire, stop,” I moaned but she couldn’t hear me. I wasn’t really there.

“She’s enjoying being alive,” the Ghost of Christmas Present said to me. “You know, you’re never more alive than when you’re eating, drinking, being merry, partying, singing, dancing and having sex. All these things we do on Christmas Day because Christmas itself is a celebration of being alive. Are you alive, Paul Scroogie? Being wealth doesn’t make you alive, does it? It might bring self-worth. It might make you feel satisfied, successful, powerful. But does it make you any more alive? Man is only on this earth for a short while. Live, while you can. That’s what Claire is doing.”

“Oh no,” I groaned as the darker of the two men got on top of her and shoved his cock into her pussy. Claire’s hands went to his ass, pulling him deeper into her and begging him to fuck her hard and not to hold back.

“You’re saying ‘oh no’ but your little penis is saying ‘oh yes’,” the giant laughed out loud, a booming sound that only we could hear. I looked down and saw that he was right. My penis was fully erect, pointing up towards the ceiling like it always did because of its short length.

“I can’t help being aroused,” I defended myself. “Look at my Claire. She’s stunning. Any man would get turned on seeing her have sex.”

“Even when she’s your woman?” the giant mused. “And she’s having sex with two strangers that she’s only just met? If you find that arousing, you should tell her. Live, Paul Scrogie. You need to learn to live.”

It was arousing. I watched for a short time longer, seeing Claire get the fuck of her life from these two young men. They took it in turns to enjoy her, one fucking her from on top or from behind while she sucked off the other. I looked down at my dick, wishing the Ghost wasn’t here so I could play with it and relieve myself of the sexual tension that was growing inside.

Just as the first of the men came - Claire had already had two strong orgasms while we’d watched - the white guy spraying her large round tits with a shower of sticky semen, the Ghost put his hand on my shoulder and I turned to him, dragging my eyes from the sexy spectacle for a moment.

“This is Christmas Day evening,” he said to me, scratching a hand through his ginger beard in thought. “You know everything you need to know but remember this is Christmas Day evening. I must go now. Do what you will with the knowledge that you have learned tonight, Paul Scrogie but heed one thing from me. You must live.”

And with that, the room around me disappeared, folding into darkness like a house of cards tumbling to the ground and the Ghost of Christmas Present this time went with it.

I was in the spare bedroom once more. The holly and mistletoe wreaths were gone, the fireplace too. Everything was back to normal.

I walked with a heavy heart and a hard penis back to my own bedroom but as I pushed open the door, there was one final spirit waiting for me.

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Chapter 7

“And who are you?” I asked the black-cloaked apparition standing at the foot of my bed.

The thing lifted a dark-sleeved arm and I saw that its hand was emaciated, almost like that of a skeleton. I shuddered and took a step back.

It didn’t reply so I guessed.

“I’ve met the Ghost of Christmas Past and of Christmas Present, so am I right to assume you’re the Ghost of Christmas Future?”

The thing nodded, its cowl hiding its face, for which I was grateful. Then it walked over to the window, which was once again open and beckoned me towards it with an emaciated finger.

Cautiously, I joined it at the window, looking out once more at the snow-covered street outside. There were no phantoms this time. Everything was quiet and peaceful.

Then we moved. I don’t know how to describe it. The street blurred, as though we were looking through a camera changing focus and when it refocused we were somewhere different.

“I think we’ve lost a resident,” I heard someone say and I turned around to see a portly woman talking to a man I recognised as Nick - the man from the care home who I’d so bluntly turned away that afternoon. He looked older, only by a few years but there was definitely some grey in his hair and lines around his eyes that I didn’t recall seeing earlier.

“Which room?” Nick replied, sadness evident on his face.

“Room 8,” the woman replied. “I just went to check on him and I don’t think he’s breathing. The nurse is in there now.”

“Oh no,” Nick’s voice broke as he spoke. “Not on Christmas night. That’s a shame, even for a man like him.”

Nick walked away down the corridor of the care home that I realised we were in. The care home he worked for. I looked at the shade next to me and it pointed in the direction Nick had walked, ordering me to follow.

As I did, I passed two other people talking in a doorway. “No one will miss him, that’s for sure,” said a tall, angular woman.

“I don’t think he’s ever had the visitor the whole year he’s been here,” an asian man replied. “I know he’s got a girlfriend but they had some sort of falling out and she hasn’t been here since. Not even when his illness got worse. They say he’s heartless and doesn’t care about anyone.”

I left the people behind, turning a corner and following Nick towards room 8.

“Is he dead, this man they’re talking about?” I asked the shade and it nodded, still not speaking a word.

“I’m sorry, Nick,” an older lady said as we reached room 8 and stepped inside. There was a body in the bed, though his face was covered by the sheet which was pulled over him to preserve his dignity. “He’s gone.”

“That’s three in the past week,” Nick said and I saw that he was sobbing. The old woman put her arms around him and comforted him.

“You do everything you can,” the woman said softly to the crying Nick. “You make their lives better. You look after them at the end and they appreciate it. Even this miserable old shit, although he never once said ‘thank you’ I know he appreciated you looking after him. You’re a remarkable man, Nick.”

“Thank you,” he replied. “But I’m not. I’m just human. I wish more people were.”

“Me too,” said the old woman, as Nick moved away, rubbing the tears from his cheeks.

“I get it,” I said to the black-garbed ghost standing next to me. “This is a warning. You’re showing me what could happen to me if I don’t change my ways. That I could be like this man - missed by no one - loved by no one. Only cared for by a total stranger at the end, out of pity and sorrow. I understand. Now, can we leave? I have no wish to see more.”

The ghost pointed - first to a calendar on the wall, then to the bed with the dead man in it.

“Three years from now,” I noted the date. “What are you trying to tell me, spirit?”

Then I looked at the bed, as Nick pulled back the sheets to say goodbye to the resident of room 8.

It was me.

“No,” I moaned. “No, no, no. This can’t be true. I’m barely fifty, spirit. I’m fit and healthy. This can’t be true.”

The Ghost of Christmas Future turned to face me, its face hidden in shadow. It nodded, then pointed to me before drawing a long bony finger across the darkness where its throat should be.

I looked at myself, pale and drawn in death. My eyes stared up at the ceiling before Nick closed them with one hand, then recovered my face and walked out of the room, leaving my corpse all alone once more.

Then the room blurred out of focus again before sharpening to a new scene at the side of an open grave. I watched in horrified silence as the funeral directors lowered my coffin down into the ground and then began shovelling soil on top of it. The only two people standing at the graveside

was a man - in his twenties, I would guess - that looked uncannily like me and Bobbi, all dressed in black with a huge baby bump sprouting from the belly of her unfastened overcoat.

“Tim,” I sobbed. “My son. And Bobbi. They’re the only ones who attended my funeral.”

The shade nodded.

“I wish he’d loved me,” I heard Tim say.

“I’m sure he did,” Bobbi told my son, who I noticed had tear-streaked cheeks. “He just didn’t know how to say it. Not to anyone.”

“I don’t think so,” Tim replied. “Everyone I invited to the funeral refused. They all said he was a hideous, bitter, old man who cared for nothing but his bank balance. Even Claire, his girlfriend, left him when he got ill because he told her he hated her. How could he hate the one woman who stayed with him through it all?”

“I don’t know,” Bobbi replied, her hand unconsciously rubbing her belly. “I don’t think he hated her at all. I think he pushed her away. Perhaps he didn’t want her to suffer watching him die.”

“Or perhaps he just didn’t want her to inherit any of his money,” Tim suggested. “He’s left it all to me but I don’t want it. All I ever wanted was his love. Not his money. He never understood that.”

“No, no, no,” I sobbed. “I’ve left my entire estate to him in my will and he doesn’t want it. What will I do, spirit? Tell me, what do I do?”

As the funeral scene faded into darkness, the Ghost of Christmas Present turned to face me once more and pulled down its cowl. Its face was as hideous as I feared, barely more than a skull, with no eyes or lips but then it changed, morphing first into the face of Marlene.

“Learn from your mistakes,” she said softly. “Tell people you love them, while you still have the opportunity.”

Then it changed again. Now, I was looking at Bella.

“Learn what is truly important to you,” my ex-wife whispered. “And what is not.”

“Care for those who can’t care for themselves,” said Nick.

“Just be nice sometimes,” Bobbi smiled at me. “A little goodwill goes a long way.”

“Embrace being a family,” Fred’s face was sad. “Some people don’t have that luxury.”

“Make your legacy what others would want it to be,” my son told me. “Not what you think they might want.”

“Live your life for the moment,” Claire’s beautiful mouth breathed the words into the darkness. “Let go of your inhibitions. Be free. Free from the chains of your own making.”

Then the Ghost pulled up its cowl once more, casting the many faces into shadow.

“What you have seen is the future,” it growled in a deep voice that sounded like the rumble of an earthquake. “The future as things stand now. You can change it, mortal man that you are.”

“I can?” I whimpered, my entire body shaking with remorse and misery.

“My time is gone,” the spirit continued, the words seeming to vibrate through me. “Don’t let yours be too, Paul Scrogie.”

And with that he was gone and the darkness with it.

I looked around, trying to overcome a horrible sense of disorientation, like I’d drunk far too much brandy the night before. The room around me seemed to spin, before slowing to reveal that I was sitting upright - in bed - in my own bedroom.

I waited for the nausea in my stomach to pass, then managed to throw back the covers - I was in bed, in my pyjamas - so I swung my legs out and stood up, rather unsteadily.

Walking over the window which was once again closed, I drew back the curtains to see the sun rising over the horizon. It was morning. But which morning? I grabbed the TV remote and turned on the television, flicking through the channels until I got to a news channel - with the date and time in the corner.

“It’s Christmas Day,” I said, breathing a huge sigh of relief. “I can change things. I will change things.”

I showered and dressed as quickly as I could, making sure I had my wallet in my coat pocket as I stepped out of the house - feeling and enjoying the cold bite of the snow through my shoes and the fresh sting of the bitter December wind that blew snowflakes into my face.

I had a plan. It was early, so I had enough time to execute it, as long as I got everything done in the right order. First was the butcher’s shop. I knew the butcher, a fellow almost as miserable and greedy as me - and I knew that he lived right above the shop, so as soon as I got there, I banged on the door, expecting no response - which I duly received.

I banged again and this time an upstairs window opened and the butcher leaned out.

“Scrogie?” he shouted down at me. “What the fuck? Do you know what time it is? And it’s fucking Christmas morning!”

“I know it is,” I smiled up at him. “Merry Christmas. I want to buy your biggest turkey, please.”

“Fuck off,” the man screamed down at me. “I don’t know what’s up with you Scrogie, but fuck off.”

“I’ll give you five hundred pounds,” I said, waving a wad of money that I pulled from my wallet. I had at least that much on me, if not more. I trusted

my wallet more than I trusted the banks with my money.

“Five hundred pounds?” the butcher looked at me doubtfully, then shrugged. “In that case, fine. But once you’ve got the turkey, you can fuck off, right?”

I did just that. I paid him his five hundred pounds, then happily fucked off with the turkey on my shoulder - almost breaking my back because it was that heavy - and I took it home, leaving it there for a while. I had another two errands to run yet.

My next trip took me to Bobbi’s house. I drove there - extremely slowly because of the snow - calling to the bank machine for some more cash along the way.

“Merry Christmas!” I said to my shocked young clerk as she opened the door to my third or fourth knock.

“Mr Scrogie?” she said, rubbing her eyes as though she didn’t believe it was me.

“Yes. Merry Christmas!” I repeated myself, looking her up and down. She was wearing just the white t-shirt I’d seen her in, when the Ghost of Christmas Present had brought me here. I couldn’t help picture her naked - those luscious, bigger-than-expected tits with her small, dark nipples and her totally bare pussy.

“Merry Christmas,” she replied, looking totally confused. “What are you doing here?”

“I’m sorry I’ve been a tight-fisted asshole of a boss,” I said cheerily. “I forgot to give you a Christmas bonus, so here it is.”

She looked down at the wad of money I’d just thrust into her hand. “I don’t understand,” she said slowly.

“I’m changing my ways,” I shrugged. “Buy your boyfriend something nice. He deserves it. And you deserve a pay rise, so from tomorrow, I’m doubling

your pay.”

“You are?” her boyfriend said from over her shoulder. I hadn’t seen him there. It was the same man I’d seen in the dream - which I now knew definitely hadn’t been a dream.

“I am,” I confirmed with a smile. “Anyway. Go back to bed. Make love. Be free. Have a wonderful Christmas.”

And with that, I left the bewildered young couple behind, got in the car and set off to my next destination; the care home.

“Merry Christmas!” I said (for the upteenth time that morning) to the security guard on duty. “Is Nick here?”

“Sure,” the man replied, looking me up and down. “Are you here to visit a relative or friend?”

“No,” I replied. “I want to make a donation, if that’s all right.”

“Mr Scrogie?” said Nick, as he arrived after the security guard had called him. “What are you doing here? It’s Christmas morning.”

“I know,” feeling mildly irritated that everyone seemed to feel the need to tell me what day it was. “I wanted to apologise for being so rude yesterday and to tell you that I want to sponsor the care home. Pop by my office tomorrow and we can discuss a sum that I will give to you every month.”

“Really?” Nick’s face changed from doubt to a smile as I nodded. “That would be fantastic. Why the change of heart?”

“Hearts change sometimes,” I replied vaguely. “I will see you tomorrow - no, that’s Boxing Day. You should spend that with friends and family. See me anytime after that. I will make time for you and we will set up a regular payment. I want to help.”

I left a shocked Nick behind and got back in the car. This felt amazing. I felt amazing. People were smiling at me. I saw joy - even if it was a surprised kind of joy - in their faces and it felt good.

But now those two things were out of the way - me making up for the errors of my ways in a professional way - there were more personal issues I needed to deal with and they weren't going to be quite as easy.

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Chapter 8

“Fred,” Helen said over her shoulder as she opened the door to me. “You’re not going to believe who’s here.”

“Who?” my brother said from behind her, then his face broke into a huge grin. “Paul. You came.”

“I did,” I smiled back, then hoisted the huge bird in my hands. “If you can let me in, that’d be great. This thing weighs a ton.”

“Oh, god, look, a turkey,” Paul said, helping me in with it. “This is great.”

“Get it in the oven,” Helen said as we walked through into the kitchen.

“Who are you?” said a little girl - the girl I’d seen last night in the visions. She was standing in front of me, just five years old, with her hair all messy and a sheet of torn Christmas wrapping in her hand.

“I’m your uncle Paul,” I replied, worried about how she might react.

“Yay,” she screamed. “I love you, Uncle Paul.”

With that, she leapt into my arms and as I picked her up and hugged her tightly, I saw Fred and Helen share a look - the same bewildered but happy look that everyone else had given me this morning.

I spent some time with my niece and nephew, playing with their gifts with them then realised I hadn’t given them anything myself, or Fred or Helen, for that matter.

“I don’t want your money, Paul,” my brother said, as I tried to shove a wad of cash into his hand. “I’m just glad you’re here. That’s the best present I

could have asked for.”

He took me into an embrace, just as he had yesterday morning, but this time, I hugged him back. Again, such a human thing to do - and it felt good - but with Fred, there was something there which held me back still. He’d fucked my ex-wife, while we were together - and I didn’t know what to do about that.

Later that afternoon, after we’d eaten - our bellies full to bursting point - Helen asked me if I’d like to help with the washing-up. I couldn’t say no. I’d just enjoyed their hospitality and Fred seemed happy to have gotten out of that particular chore as I followed her into the kitchen.

“I wanted to talk,” Helen said, closing the door so the kids and Fred couldn’t hear.

“I guessed that,” I replied, passing her some of the dirty dishes as she began to fill up the sink.

“Why are you here?” she asked me, pushing a lock of light brown hair out of her ice-blue eyes. “Why are you really here? Do you want something, or...?”

“I know,” I interrupted her. “It’s weird that I’m here. You probably don’t trust this sudden change of heart, do you?”

“I don’t trust anyone apart from my children,” Helen said, avoiding my gaze as she began to wash up. She passed me a teatowel. “I’ll wash. You can dry. Now tell me why you’re here.”

“This morning, I gave my receptionist a huge Christmas bonus and a pay rise,” I shrugged as she passed me the first plate to dry and place in the rack. “I’m also giving money to the care home every month from now on. I’ve changed, Helen.”

“Really?” Those pale blue eyes bored into my face. “Why?”

“Some things have come to light,” I tried to explain. “Things I didn’t know. I’ve been made to look in a mirror. And I didn’t like what I saw.”

“What things?” Helen said, pausing halfway through scrubbing the next plate.

“I put work and business first,” I replied honestly. “All my life, I’ve put it first. I put it before my wife. It put it before my family. And I can’t explain how, but I woke up this morning and saw where it will lead me.”

“You’re being weird,” Helen replied, finishing cleaning the plate and handing it to me.

“It is weird,” I told her, “What happened to me. It was an epiphany of sorts, I suppose.”

“So you’ve changed. Just like that. Overnight, you’ve just changed.” She snapped a finger to emphasize what she was saying.

“No, not really,” I answered. “But I’m trying to. One step at a time, I’m going to try to be a better person, Helen. If it’s too late - if people don’t trust me - or won’t let me back into their lives, then I have to accept that. But I have to try.”

“I just don’t want Fred getting hurt.” She turned to face me. “I swear, Paul, if you’re messing around or playing some sort of game and he gets hurt, I’ll...”

“You absolutely love him, don’t you?” I asked quietly. “Even though he was fucking Bella - and you know he was - you still love him and want to protect him. Despite how he hurt you, you still want to protect him from being hurt. That’s either admirable or foolish, I’m not sure which.”

Helen’s face paled. “What?”

“I know he had sex with Bella,” I told her gently. “They even had sex one Christmas Day, right here in this house. Upstairs, in the bathroom. I know that you know, Helen. I’m not stupid.”

“What?” she repeated. “How? Why...?”

“It’s fine,” I reassured her, realising what she might be thinking. “I’m not here for any sort of revenge. What happened in the past is gone. It happened. I cheated on Bella too. It’s why we split up. The past is the past. I just want to be part of a family. Please believe me. I want to be a better person and being a better brother and uncle is part of that. Please, Helen.”

She didn’t reply for a few moments. She just stood there, watching me, perhaps working out what to do or what to say. Then she stripped off the apron and rubber gloves that she was wearing, took my hand in hers and led me out of the kitchen towards the stairs.

“Come with me and be quiet,” she said in as stern a tone as I’d ever heard come from her mouth.

“Okay,” I replied as she dragged me up the stairs and into the bathroom where I’d seen Fred fuck Bella in the visions of the past. “What are you doing?”

Helen was undoing the buttons on my jeans, then tugged them down and pulled my cock out of my boxer shorts. She said nothing about me being small, she just opened her mouth and started sucking it.

“Helen,” I hissed in shock. “What the fuck are you doing?”

“I’m fucking you,” she said once my cock was nice and hard. Then she lifted her t-shirt up over her breasts and pulled her white bra cups down so that her large, slightly-droopy tits were out. “Suck my tits.”

I bent my head, taking one of her large nipples into my mouth as she undid and wriggled out of her jeans.

“Helen,” I hissed again, worried that Fred or one of the kids was going to come upstairs and catch us. “We can’t do this. What if...?”

“Shut up and fuck me,” she cut me off, then bent over the bath, spreading her thighs. She had a nice-looking pussy even if it was hairy with thick

pubes much darker than the hair on her head.

“I can’t,” I said. “You’re my sister-in-law.”

“Bella was Fred’s sister-in-law. Didn’t stop him.” Helen looked over her shoulder at me. “Now, if you want to be part of this family, you’re going to help me get even. You’re going to fuck me and cum inside me. Just like he did with Bella. And unless you want to explain to Fred and the children why we were in the bathroom together, you had better do it fast.”

“Good point,” I sighed. We were here now. Whether we had sex or not, there’d be some explaining to do. She wanted to get even. I could understand that. I’d be even too.

I moved behind her, guiding my dick into her hairy pussy and grabbing her hips, I fucked Helen. She felt good - surprisingly tight to say she’d had two children - and the moans she made were a turn-on, spurring me on to fuck her harder and faster.

“That’s good,” she groaned. “Cum inside me, Paul.”

I kicked her feet a little further apart, lowering her and enjoying the slight extra depth that it gave me when penetrating her then rammed my cock into her as hard as I’d ever fucked anyone until I felt my toes curl and my ass cheeks tense as I pumped my load into her.

“That was actually quite good,” Helen grinned, her face flushed as she pulled up her panties and jeans. “We can make this a regular thing, if you like. Just like Fred and Bella did.”

“I don’t know about that,” I replied, hurriedly tidying myself up too and then leaving the bathroom carefully, making sure that neither Fred nor the kids were around.

“Well, I hope we’re not just going to see you at Christmas,” Helen replied quietly as we tip-toed down the stairs. “I’d like you to see us regularly. Fred and the kids would too but remember, he works during the day. Both the

children are at school now, so you could call around any time while I'm on my own."

I couldn't believe what she was saying but it was certainly something to think about.

"Let's just take this family thing one step at a time," I replied, peeking my head around the corner of the door and sighing in relief when I saw Fred asleep on the sofa and the two kids playing in front of the Christmas tree.

"If you're serious about wanting to be part of the family again and healing old wounds," Helen said, steering me back towards the sink full of pots before re-donning the apron and gloves. "Then part of that healing process means keeping me happy."

"I've got Claire to consider," I said, picking up the tea towel again and drying the first saucepan she cleaned and then passed to me.

"I know you do," Helen shrugged. "But if you don't know this already, I hate to be the one to break this to you but..."

"She's fucking other guys," I finished the sentence for her. "I know that too. She's young. I can't fulfil her needs like she wants."

"Does she know that you know?" Helen's pale blue eyes were wide. "Or is it like an arrangement sort of thing? Are you swingers or something?"

"No," I laughed. "It's nothing like that. She doesn't know that I know. Not yet, at least. Listen, after we've done the pots, I'll have an hour with Fred and the kids, then I have to go - okay?"

"You're going to see her, aren't you?" I was surprised at how clever Helen was. Those pale blue eyes of her saw through me, I knew that now.

"I used to think you hated me," I said, avoiding the question. She knew the answer anyway.

"I resented you," Helen nodded. "For hurting Fred. For your wife fucking my husband, I blamed you for some reason. I thought if you'd somehow

had control of her, it wouldn't have happened. But I never hated you. I always quite fancied you, Paul, if I'm honest."

"Well, that's something I didn't know," I smiled, feeling rather embarrassed at her admission for some reason.

An hour later; an hour well-spent playing with my lovely niece and nephew, I got into the car after an emotional goodbye with Fred during which he made me promise to see him next week for the New Year's celebration.

I had just two more things to do. Two more things to set right.

First, was Claire. I knew where she was and I started up the car to drive there.

To the Plaza Hotel.

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Chapter 9

I walked into the luxurious foyer of the Plaza Hotel and strolled past the reception and customers drinking in the bar, after checking that Claire and her boyfriends weren't there. In my vision last night, I hadn't known the exact time they were having sex but I did know it was the evening. The Ghost of Christmas Present had made a point of telling me. He knew I could do this. He knew I could change things, even before the Ghost of Christmas Future had told me so.

One thing I had noticed and unconsciously committed to memory was the room number. I'd seen the keycard on the table top and my mathematical information-sponge of a brain had remembered it without me even trying. My fantastic memory and brain had made me into a good businessman, but now it was serving a new purpose - it was going to save my relationship.

Room 112 was at the end of the first-floor corridor and I stopped outside the door, pondering my next move. I couldn't get in - the door was locked, obviously. What did I do? Did I knock? I had a plan when I came here, but I hadn't worked out all of the minutiae.

I pressed an ear to the door first, wanting to make sure they were actually in the room. For all I knew, the men might not have arrived yet - or they might have already left. Claire might even have gone somewhere with them.

I heard her. A low moan but it was definitely her. I'd gotten here at precisely the right time. She was having sex right now, presumably with the two men I'd seen in the visions - right now on the other side of this door.

There was nothing else for it. I knocked. Loudly, so that they'd hear over the noises of their threesome.

"Who is it?" I heard my girlfriend call out a moment later.

“It’s me, Claire,” I replied simply. “It’s Paul.”

There was a long silence.

“Paul?” she replied through the door, sounding panicked. “What are you doing here? How did you know I was here?”

I could hear all kinds of movement coming from inside the room, no doubt the two men scrambling to get dressed. I smiled to myself, imagining them hiding in the bathroom or perhaps on the balcony until I went away again.

“I know everything, Claire,” I replied, trying to keep my voice as friendly and calm as I could. “And I want you to know it’s fine. I love you and what you’re doing is perfectly understandable. I just want to talk about it.”

“You know what I’m doing?” she said through the door, sounding like she was directly on the other side now. She was probably looking through the peephole, wondering what the fuck was happening and checking that it really was me and not someone playing a prank. “What do you mean by ‘what I’m doing?’ I’m not doing anything. I’m just chilling out. All on my own. I’m sorry I lied about going to my family. I just wanted some time alone, you see, and...”

“Claire,” I said softly. “I said ‘I love you.’ Did you hear me?”

“I heard you,” she said, then paused before speaking further. “I love you too,” she said, hesitantly. “What’s going on?”

“Let me in,” I said again. “Just let me in so I can talk to you properly and not through a slab of wood. And tell whoever you’ve got in there to chill. I’m not going to do anything.”

“I don’t have anyone in here with me,” Claire said, as she opened the door and beckoned me inside. She did appear to be alone, wearing a fluffy white bathrobe around her that reminded me of the scene I’d seen with Bella, also in a hotel room. I pushed the thought from my mind. Bella was yesteryear. Claire was now. This was about her.

“Wherever you are, you can come out,” I said out loud as I closed the door behind me.

“I don’t know who you’re talking to,” Claire protested, watching me carefully as I walked over and sat on the bed next to her.

“I heard you fucking,” I told her. “Through the door. I could hear you.”

“I was masturbating,” she said, impressing me with her speed of thought.

“Listen, dude, I’m sorry.” The dark-skinned young man was the first to emerge from his hiding place behind the curtains. He’d managed to get dressed. “I didn’t know she had a boyfriend or whatever you are. Please don’t make a scene. I’ll just leave and let you sort it out.”

I looked at Claire and she cringed in shame, then cringed even more when the white guy walked out of the bathroom.

“I’m sorry too,” he apologised, looking terrified as he backed away towards the door.

“Don’t go,” I told them both, jumping up from the bed which startled them both and moving so I was between the exit and them, blocking them from leaving. “It’s fine. Claire is my girlfriend, but it’s cool. She likes fucking other guys. I’m old and past it. My dick is like an acorn. She’s only twenty-eight. She enjoys sex. It’s just harmless fun. I get it.”

The two men looked at each other, as if working out between them how sincere I was being but my eyes were on Claire. She was still sitting on the edge of the bed, looking as glamorous, sexy and beautiful as always, despite being interrupted mid-fuck. Her green eyes were studying me, trying to figure me out. Claire had always had the measure of me. I hadn’t forgotten that.

“Have you been spying on me?” she asked. “Following me? Have you been checking my phone? You must have been, to know I was here and what I was doing.”

“Listen,” I replied. “I can’t explain how I know what you’ve been doing, but one night when we’re alone - tomorrow, whenever - I will explain. Not that you’ll believe me. But I promise, I haven’t been following you or doing any of that.”

“Can we leave now?” the white model guy said, after apologising for interrupting.

“No,” I said firmly. “You came here to fuck Claire and you’re not leaving until you’ve done just that.”

“This is kinda weird,” the mixed-race youngster said. “You have to forgive us if we seem freaked out, but it is weird.”

“I know it’s weird,” I shrugged. “But look, I’m going to lay my cards on the table. When I found out my girlfriend has been having sex with random men, it turned me on. I’ve been straight-laced all my life. Perhaps it’s the way I was brought up. I’ve never allowed myself to show much emotion. I’ve never let go of my rigid rules. In some ways, I’ve never lived. I just want to do something crazy. I want to see my girlfriend get fucked in front of me. The thought of it turns me on.”

“Are you telling me the truth?” Claire asked, suddenly standing up. She slid the bathrobe from her shoulders to reveal the red bra I’d seen last night. Her panties were already discarded at the side of the bed, I’d already noticed. “Or are you fucking with me, Paul?”

“I’m not fucking with you,” I pleaded. “I’m so horny right now. Look.”

I pulled down my jeans and shorts to reveal my less-than-impressive erection, feeling a moment of shame but at the same time also feeling an intense arousal that these two young studs were probably inwardly laughing at my size.

“I always thought you were a square. A stiff.” Claire allowed herself a small grin as she looked at my penis. “That is very stiff, isn’t it? Are you really turned on by this?”

“I don’t ever want to lose you, Claire,” I poured my heart out to her. “I love you. I’m sorry I’ve never really shown it. It’s taken until today for me to realise that and if fucking other men is what it will take for you to be happy and for you to always stay with me, then so be it.”

“The fact that it obviously turns you on is a bonus,” the white model guy added.

“When I want you to talk, I’ll ask,” Claire rounded on him. “You’re here to fuck me, not give me and my boyfriend relationship advice.”

“So, let’s fuck then,” he shrugged then turned to me. “If you’re sure that’s okay with you?”

“It’s more than okay,” I said, taking a deep breath, scarcely able to believe this was about to happen. “Please. Be my guest.”

The dark-skinned, tattooed guy was already stripping his clothes back off and the white model guy joined him in getting naked, then the two men joined Claire on the bed. She removed her bra, letting her large fake tits fall free.

“I do not want to see you touch yourself,” she said sternly to me. “Save that erection for me, for when I’ve done with these two boys.”

“Fair enough,” I said, fastening my trousers back up and sitting down on the dressing table chair to watch what was about to happen.

“Now where were we?” Claire asked the two men.

“I was fucking you from behind,” the dark-skinned one replied.

“That’s right,” my girlfriend flashed me a grin, then got onto all fours on the bed. “Okay, Leon, fuck me again. Glenn, let me suck your cock. Let’s show my boyfriend how real men fuck a lady.”

The white guy, Glenn, positioned himself in front of her face and I watched as she began to hungrily suck his impressive cock just as she had in the

visions and at the same time, Leon shoved his brown penis into her from behind and began to slowly have sex with her.

“I said, ‘show my boyfriend how real men fuck,’ not ‘how real men make love,’” Claire looked at Leon over her shoulder and he nodded that he understood and began to pound her mercilessly as she returned to sucking Glenn.

Fuck. This was hot. I should be jealous. I should feel envious, angry, betrayed. But I didn't. I just felt turned on. Like I'd explained to the Ghost of Christmas Present last night, it was like watching porn with a stunning woman, only that woman was my girlfriend.

“Can I come closer?” I asked, as they swapped ends. “I want to see it actually going in.”

“Sure,” Claire smiled, seemingly enjoying my curiosity.

I knelt by the bed, my head no more than a foot away from her thigh as I watched Glenn's girthy penis split open Claire's pussy lips. As he shoved it in deeper, I took in how her labia were stretched out around his thickness. It looked incredible, better than on-screen porn - and I could smell it too. The smell of sex, of pre-cum, pussy juice and sweat. The whole thing was amazing.

“He's going to make me cum,” Claire told me, her green eyes holding mine right as her orgasm hit her. Once her legs had finished quivering from the powerful climax, she pushed Glenn from her and told Leon to lay on his back. “I want Paul to watch me ride you,” she said, squatting over him and guiding his dark, long dick into her.

I sat on the edge of the bed, watching his dark hands against her white skin as he fondled her large tits, squeezing and pinching her nipples as she bounced up and down slowly on his length.

“I'm going to cum,” Glenn said. He was standing on the bed, watching them fuck like I was, but was jerking his cock rapidly.

“On my face,” Claire moaned, one finger circling her clit as she rode Leon’s dick. “My face and my tits.”

Glenn moved closer, pointing his cock at her and then I saw a thick white jet shoot out, hitting her on the cheek, then another landing on her chin before he squeezed out the final few squirts onto her tits. Some of his cum dribbled off and landed on Leon, but the dark-skinned youngster didn’t seem to care. He was thrusting his hips upwards, meeting Claire’s downwards movements, their groins thudding together and just as Claire orgasmed again, causing her to topple sideways onto the bed next to him, he jumped up onto his knees, wanking his cock so fast his hand was a blur and shooting his own load all over tits too.

“Oh my god,” Claire groaned after Leon had done milking his dick, squeezing out the last few drops into her open mouth. “I needed that. Thank you, boys, You should get dressed and leave now. I need to sort Paul out as promised.”

I sat there, not knowing what to say as they promptly dressed and left, finally leaving Claire and me alone.

“Did you really enjoy that?” she asked, doubt returning to her voice and face. “Or are you going to kick me to the kerb because it was all an elaborate lie or a trap or something.”

I didn’t say anything. I just tugged my trousers back down and got on top of her, shoving my hard cock into her wet pussy. Then I fucked her as hard as I could, knowing I wouldn’t last long because I was so turned on. Once I’d emptied my load inside her, I rolled off and smiled.

“Merry Christmas,” I said. “I love you, Claire. I’m not kicking you to the kerb. In fact, I’m doing the opposite. I want you to marry me.”

“I’m not accepting that as a proposal,” Claire sneered at me. “You can buy me the biggest diamond I’ve ever seen tomorrow, get down on one knee and propose properly. If you really want to marry me, that is.”

“I do,” I said as earnestly as I could. “You can still fuck other men, whenever you want but I have one condition.”

“What’s that?” she asked, a genuinely happy smile growing on her face.

“You don’t let them cum inside you?”

“But I like that,” Claire raised an eyebrow. “I like the feeling of it.”

“Just not until I’ve gotten you pregnant,” I explained. “I want you to come off the pill. I want to give you a baby.”

“Really?” she rolled over to me, putting one arm over me and kissing me softly on the lips. “Don’t mess with me, Paul. Are you being genuine? This seems too good to be true, this change in you.”

“I’m a changed man,” I replied. “Let me prove it to you.”

I had one last thing to do. One last mistake to fix. I got up and collected my phone from my pocket, then punched in a number I hadn’t rung in a long, long time.

“Tim?” I said, when my son answered. “It’s me. Your dad. I’m calling to say Merry Christmas. I know it’s been a long time, son but I love you.”

After the conversation had finished, I put the phone down and Claire rushed over to me, pulling me into a tight embrace.

“I love you,” she said, tears bright in her green eyes.

“I love you too,” I said. “Merry Christmas.”

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Epilogue

“Mr Scrogie?” Bobbi said, poking her head around my office door.
“Everyone’s gone home. Can I have that private meeting with you now?”

“Of course you can,” I said, with a smile. “Come in.”

Bobbi walked in and closed the door behind her, then she took her top off while I undid my trousers. “Can we fuck on the desk again?” she asked excitedly. “I love it on the desk.”

“Come on then,” I nodded, sliding everything from the wooden surface onto the floor so that the now-naked girl could climb up and lay down on top of it. I took hold of her chocolate-coloured thighs and slid her to the edge until her shaved pussy was close enough for me to slide my erect little cock inside her.

“Fuck me, sir,” she begged. “I’ve been really bad again today. While you were out, I didn’t do a thing. I just sat and painted my nails. I need punishing.”

“You are a terrible employee, Bobbi. I can’t leave you alone for even an hour without you taking advantage,” I half-shouted at her, taking her nipples between my fingers and tweaking them hard until she yelped. I had been out all afternoon - at Helen’s house - fucking her while Fred was at work.

“I promise I’ll do better tomorrow,” Bobbi replied, then groaned as I rammed my cock in her quicker and harder. “Please don’t take away my pay rise.”

“I won’t,” I replied. “As long as you promise to look after this baby of mine.” I rubbed her bulging stomach. “And as long as you’re willing to let

me fuck you whenever I want, you can work here and keep your payrises coming.”

“You can fuck me whenever you want to, Mr Scrogie,” she smiled at me. She loved this roleplay game we played every week or so. I wasn’t sure if the baby in her belly was mine or not, but Bobbi assured me it was, going by the dates she’d been given by the hospital. Helen had also told me that the unexpected pregnancy she was going through was down to me as well. She claimed that Fred and her hadn’t had sex at all during the month she’d conceived, so it must be mine. She was slightly worried about Fred working it out, but that was a bridge we’d cross when we came to it.

Claire was pregnant too. She’d come off the pill the day after I’d proposed to her, but I knew for a fact that she’d been letting her lovers cum inside her so I wasn’t sure if the baby was mine or not, but I didn’t care. We were the happiest we’d ever been and even if I ended up raising a child that wasn’t mine, if Bobbi and Helen were both telling the truth, I’d already gotten two other babies on the way too. At least one of them had to be mine. Let Fred and Bobbi’s boyfriend think the children were theirs, I’d look after all three financially, no matter what.

“I’m going to cum inside you now,” I told Bobbi, pushing her legs up and back so I could get it in nice and deep.

“Please do, sir,” she groaned as I pumped my spunk into her young pussy. “I love your cum inside me.”

Once we’d finished - Bobbi liked to sit on my knee and kiss for a while after having our roleplay sex - she reminded me of something as she got dressed and ready to go home to her boyfriend.

“Don’t forget,” she said. “You’re having dinner with your son tonight. Don’t be late.”

“I hadn’t forgotten,” I replied. I was really looking forward to finally seeing Tim again. “But thanks for reminding me.”

“I’m your secretary,” Bobbi shrugged and smiled. “It’s my job.”

Once she'd gone, I sat down and surveyed my desk for a moment. My entire life had changed. It had improved in so many ways, I couldn't begin to count them.

A draught blew through the office, sweeping some of the papers onto the floor, from where I'd only just picked them up after fucking Bobbi.

Marlene was dead, to begin with. I knew that. But I also knew that she was here - with me - watching invisibly.

And I hoped that somehow, by fixing me, she had managed to cast off her chains. As I'd hopefully unforged mine.

"Thank you," I said to the spirit that I knew was with me right then. The spirit who I knew had once loved me. And who I'd loved back. "I love you, Marlene."

The draught blew again, a cool blast of air sweeping around my ankles, confirming that she was there.

As I locked the warehouse door behind me, I looked up at the sign over my head. Paul Scrogie and Marlene Jacobs, it read. She'd been dead eight years but I'd never take her name off that sign. I owed her everything.

"Hi, stranger," Bella said, as I met her in the car park like we'd arranged on the way to have dinner with our son. "It's been a long, long time."

"It has," I smiled, taking her into my arms for a hug and enjoying the feeling of her against me. I'd gotten in touch with her after speaking to Tim regularly since that fateful Christmas Day. He told me his mother would like that to see me again. And so here we were.

"We've got a lot to talk about," she said, holding my hand as we walked towards the restaurant. "A lot of catching up to do."

"We certainly do," I replied, already working out in my head how I was going to talk her into letting me fuck her.

Life was good. And it was going to get better.

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A Note to the Reader

I just wanted to say thank you very much for purchasing my book, and reading it right to the end! At least I hope you did, and that you didn't just skip forward!

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Thanks again, for buying and reading my books, it's really appreciated!

Until next time,

Paul

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About the Author

Paul Garland is a Sheffield, UK based author of erotic novels and short stories, guaranteed to keep you turning the lust-filled pages until the early hours of the night.

Paul has been writing since the turn of the millennium but only turned to the erotica genre in 2018 with his Cerulean Erotica Presents series and No Angels series of books which rapidly gained him a following. In 2020, he began 'The Cuckold Collection,' a brand new collection of cuckold-themed books and two new series of shorter stories: The No Angels Shorts and The Sexy Season Shorts and has yet another as-yet-untitled series in the works for 2021.

His website is here. It's got his blog and a link to all of his books.

His mailing list is here - sign up for the latest news on new releases and special offers. Every person that signs up receives a free book (email to let him know you've joined though) so do it today!

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